only day when both teams train simultaneously. It doesn't feature the sort of Christmas spread where you can gorge yourself silly, but there's still turkey, oysters, and pizza and chips for the kids.

Andy Flower ruffled a few feathers by hosting a pre-tour lunch for wives and partners, at which he expanded on their responsibilities and explained the practicalities of an international cricketer's life. There would be times, for instance, that we would travel ahead of our families, because of recovery programmes and training schedules. Alice would never cause an issue for me but found it something of an eye-opener.

The party hat was on, but my mind was elsewhere. As cold as it seems, you've got to have a very clear appreciation of boundaries. There were days when I'd get back from the ground and want to slob out, even though Alice had looked forward to dinner. There were other days when she kicked me out of the door; I enjoyed the release of normality, instead of hiding away.

It is easy to forget we are dealing with people, rather than cartoon characters. Australia as a nation yearned for reassurance in the build-up to that match, and turned to Ricky Ponting, as a symbol of hope. He was front, back and centre of the papers. They recreated him as Punter, the superhero who would save the day by batting through the pain of a broken finger.

Since their media can be vicious in the event of disappointment, that wasn't an entirely comfortable place to be. They had named a seventeen-man squad, which suggested they didn't seem entirely sure of their best side, and we had been decisive to the point of brutality. Steve Finn, our leading wicket taker, was told he was dropped on Christmas Day.

Happy holidays …

It's professional sport. It's hard and harsh. It shouldn't really matter on what day the big decision is taken. He was left out because he was being hit for four runs an over. It was the equivalent of dropping your most productive batsman for scoring too slowly, a brave call, made after exhaustive discussions between captain and coach.

Tim Bresnan came in. Straussy gambled on the accuracy of our seamers, deciding to bowl on winning the toss. If that lager company ever did Boxing Days, this was it. It was just bloody marvellous. Australia made their lowest total against us for forty-two years: 98. They chased the ball and, excepting two early drops, we caught everything behind the wicket.

I had the best gig, watching carnage unfold from mid-off. Conditions were English, with a little rain around at lunchtime, and our bowlers were